diplomats, he also highlighted the president's lack of encouragement to Jiang.[186]

Krishna Menon's meetings had a more beneficial effect on Nehru than on Eisenhower and Dulles, who did not think that the Indian envoy understood the US viewpoint.[187] Despite the administration's desire for clarity from China on the possibility of a ceasefire and a peaceful Taiwan solution, Dulles had never been keen on Krishna Menon's visit. The secretary of state certainly did not want Krishna Menon to be an intermediary, even though he was interested in what the Chinese had told the Indian envoy.[188] Furthermore, there were key differences between the administration and Krishna Menon on potential negotiations with China. Krishna Menon recommended that China and the US discuss the big issues (Taiwan, offshore islands) and then turn to smaller ones (including American POWs being held in China). Eisenhower disagreed, noting that the question of imprisoned American POWs was not a minor issue for the US and had to be addressed first.[189]

The Problem of Prisoners: Major or Minor Issue? (1955–1956)

The prisoner question was another source of US-India debate. India was no stranger to the issue of American civilian and military prisoners detained in China after 1949—it had acted as an intermediary, including as late as 1954. Like its predecessor, the Eisenhower administration had not welcomed the Indian role. It tried to sidestep India, working instead through the UN secretary-general Dag Hammarskjold to secure the release of the prisoners.[190] The Indian refusal to send an official to accompany the secretary-general to Beijing on the grounds that China would think India was taking the US/UN side did nothing to alleviate the impression that Delhi's sympathies lay with Beijing. Nor did the Indian ambassador in Beijing's assertion that the US needed to cease its "bluster" because China would make no concessions under pressure to change that impression.[191] Zhou's indication that India was one of the two countries that China would accept as an intermediary—the other being the Soviet Union—only cemented the view.[192]

India was not, however, backing Beijing on this question. Officials did find steps like US-led condemnation of China at the UN to be unhelpful to resolving the situation.[193] But Nehru understood from his own officials, as